

Ant

Families don't get much bigger than a colony of ants. Hundreds of them share a single mom: an egg-laying queen. Most kinds of ants live in nests, but army ants from South American rain forests move from place to place as they hunt prey.

Larva to pupa

Each larva turns into a pupa. This is the stage when ants develop into adults by a complete change in body shape. Larvae and pupae cannot walk, so adult ants must carry them.

Egg to larva

Each egg grows into the next stage—a wriggling, wormlike larva, which is looked after by the workers. Ants get restless as more larvae build up.

On the move

As the larvae grow, the entire ant colony moves to a different place. The ants march in aggressive columns along trails that they mark with their scent, attacking small animals in their path.

Queen

The queen ant's body swells to lay tens of thousands of eggs per week. During this time, her workers swarm around her in a huge protective bundle.

When a swarm is settled in one place, it is called a bivouac.

Ants are virtually blind, so they rely on touch and smell to get around.

Ants swarm over insects and other prey, kill them with their stings, and pull them apart to provide meat for the colony.

This adult worker ant is carrying a pupa.